ted a vigilance report alleging an "ulterior motive of monetary gains" on the part of Sisodia and others. Exactly a week later, the AAP government scrapped the new policy and reverted to the old one for six months starting September 1, pending the formulation of revised guidelines. A July 31 cabinet note cited revenue loss and undue benefits to certain retailers as the reason. Sisodia even sought to blame former Delhi L-G Anil Baijal for his decision to make it mandatory for retailers to obtain permission from DDA and MCD for opening a shop. As many prospective retailers got caught in the bureaucratic nettle, the process allegedly gave the big fish undue advantage, claimed Sisodia.

Leaving aside the specifics (*see graphic*), the CBI's action was a blow targeted at the very core of AAP's image: its moral claim as a party born to combat corruption. Questions have been raised about its timing in the larger political context. AAP leaders, including Kejriwal and Sisodia, have been wooing Gujarat voters with the promise of incentives such as free electricity. Observers say Prime Minister Narendra Modi's recent attack on "freebie culture" was in fact triggered by this AAP campaign in his home state. Amidst all the claims, it remains indisputable that Delhi's impugned excise policy failed to achieve its primary objectives—to increase revenue and deny undue advantage to liquor cartels. Revenues fell 37.51 per cent short of the budgetary estimates for Q1, declining by Rs 193.95 crore per month since April 2022. But as even the cabinet note admitted, liquor was flying off the shelves, with the slack being picked up by the remaining licensees, resulting in windfall gains to them. Multiple retailers meanwhile exited the business—only 468 shops were operational, against the targeted 849—fuelling charges of a creeping monopolisation. ■



ANI

PINK LINE KCR at a public meeting in Munugode, Aug. 20

TELANGANA

TELANGANA TICKING...

By Amarnath K. Menon

A dizzying set of events has sent temperatures soaring over the political skies in Telangana, with various strands of the provincial and the national getting entangled in mutually aggravating ways. The upcoming byelection to the Munugode assembly seat would have been a routine headline in another time. But this time, it's set against a red-hot context: the BJP is going for broke to displace the Congress as the main challenger to the Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS) in the 2023 assembly polls, so an escalation of the pitch is audible on all planes. Hyderabad, 80-odd km west of Munugode, was boiling after a replay of the Nupur Sharma episode—with the BJP suspending MLA T. Raja Singh on August 23, hours after he was arrested for a video containing insulting references to Prophet Mohammed. The day saw another high-profile BJP arrest: state unit chief Bandi Sanjay was picked from a protest site after the BJP scaled up hostilities by alleging that Kalvakuntla Kavitha, TRS MLC and daughter of CM K. Chandrashekar Rao (KCR), was linked to the Delhi liquor scam, a claim she responded to with a defamation case.

Two days earlier, action was focused on Munugode itself, with KCR and Union home minister Amit Shah holding rallies on successive days over the weekend, giving the contest a distinct air of something much bigger than just a lone provincial bypoll—indeed, a bellwether event to judge which way Telangana is headed ahead of 2023. The resignation of Komatireddy Rajagopal Reddy, who had won the seat for the Congress in 2018, necessitated the bypoll: he 's contesting this time on a BJP ticket. It looks to be all uphill for the Congress in what's turning into a pitched battle between the TRS and the BJP. For a party that had a strong presence in Nalgonda district, within which